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Where to Begin When Medicaid Is Still a "Someday": Three First Moves for Dad's Records, Changes and Reviews

Three moves, in order, at your own pace, and what can be left for later.

Dad is managing on his own and nobody is applying for anything. You've heard that a Medicaid approval isn't the end of the process, and it's hard to know where to begin when there's no letter to answer.

Begin small. Three things, in this order, on whatever afternoon suits Dad.

1 Choose one place for Dad's records, and tell a second person where it is

With Dad, pick a drawer, a file box or a folder on his computer for his statements, legal papers, insurance and care records. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau suggests a safe, easily accessible location, with trusted family told where to find things. Keep a note with them of who would open the mail and handle the paperwork if Dad ever wanted a hand; the federal renewal flyer says a state writes to people who have Medicaid by mail. [1] [2]

WHY IT'S ON THE SHORT LIST Organized records are the part of this step a family can set up years ahead, and the usual sticking point is that only Dad knows where they are.

2 Start a short list of changes that may be coming

Write down anything your family expects in the next few years: a move, a sale, a change in income, an inheritance. A guess is fine. The nonprofit Justice in Aging notes, in general, that changes in a person's life such as moving, retiring or a rise in income can change Medicaid eligibility. Whether any change on your list would matter for Dad isn't yours to work out, so put a question mark beside each one. [3]

WHY IT'S ON THE SHORT LIST These are ordinary family plans, and once a list exists it can grow whenever something comes up.

3 Agree to ask before acting on a big one

Make it the family's habit: when a major financial change is on the way, the question goes to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney first, and the list from the second move is what you bring. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money calls Medicaid complicated and says to get legal advice about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility. [4]

WHY IT'S ON THE SHORT LIST It turns "we should look into that someday" into something the family has already agreed on, and it asks nothing of anyone today.

What can be left for later, or for a professional

- Tracking down every old statement. The folder starts with what's already in the house and what arrives from here on.
- What Dad's state would ask of him after an approval. That depends on the state and the situation, and your Medicaid planner can explain the general shape.
- Whether a change on your list would matter, or would ever have to be reported. That goes on the question list.
- A full review schedule. For now, one date to open the folder again is plenty.
- Any change to an account, a deed or a policy. Nothing in this guide calls for one.
- Whether Dad will ever need Medicaid. Nobody is deciding or predicting that.

Start with Dad

It's his paperwork, and these are moves to make with him. A plain opening works best: you'd like to know where things are kept, and you aren't taking anything over.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what Medicaid requires after an approval in Dad's state, whether any change would matter, or what to do about money or property. It puts three first moves in order. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've chosen a place for Dad's records, started a list of changes and agreed to ask before acting. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Keeping records in one place where trusted family can find them follows the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau. The point about the mail follows the federal renewal flyer, and the general point about changes follows Justice in Aging. The advice to get legal advice first is the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's. The order is ours.

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
3. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
4. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney